announcement of the blockade. He was furious. At the Kremlin reception in honor of the Romanian leadership, “Khrushchev swore at Washington, threatened to ‘nuke’ the White House, and cursed loudly every time anyone pronounced the words America or American,” wrote Pacepa. Khrushchev then surprised Gheorghiu-Dej with an invitation to join him and the rest of the Soviet leadership for a visit to the Bolshoi Theater.[1]

Khrushchev recalled designing the visit as a public relations move. He said to his aides: “Comrades, let’s go to the Bolshoi Theater. The atmosphere in the world is tense now, but we’ll make an appearance in the theater. Our people and foreigners will see it, and that will begin to have a calming effect. If Khrushchev and other leaders are sitting in the theater at such a time, then everyone can sleep soundly.” He then added: “But we ourselves were very anxious at the time.” Foreign Minister Andrei Gromyko, who was among those invited to the performance, later recalled: “I don’t remember what was playing in the theater. And probably none of the Politburo members in attendance were interested in what was happening on stage. Opera, ballet or drama—it was all the same to them all. Everyone was thinking of what was going on there, in the Western hemisphere. But they all sat properly and calmly in their seats, applauding as avid theatergoers should.”[2]

On stage was the classic Russian opera *Boris Godunov* by Modest Mussorgsky, with the Metropolitan Opera star Jerome Hines in the leading role. *Pravda* reported next day on Hines’s very successful performance: he received a standing ovation and six curtain calls. Khrushchev, according to the Romanian leader’s recollections, “went out of his way to present personal congratulations” to Hines. In the company of Gheorghiu-Dej and the Soviet leaders he went backstage, where he complimented Hines on his good Russian and raised a toast to “peace and friendship between our countries.”[3]

The Romanians, who had earlier seen Khrushchev cursing after hearing the word “America,” were not sure what to think. Khrushchev was clearly off balance. He had been caught red-handed delivering missiles to Cuba and now did not know what to do. He tried his usual bullying tactics, menacing Kennedy with veiled threats of nuclear war and talking tough in front of his communist comrades. It was especially important to do so before the